

Australia Daily Brief

Friday, September 11, 2026

1,894 words · 8 min read

RE: Chinese firm buys \$1bn of PNG mines and ports · NZ Treasury: Luxon and Peters bypassed Cabinet on Forum hosting · Fletcher says Beijing turning 'smug' · PNG court forces Solwara disclosure · Rinehart backs Hanson against Hastie

ASX 200

8,741

-2.94%

AUD/USD

0.7173

-0.46%

NZX 50

13,580

-2.82%

NZD/USD

0.5824

-1.00%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 A Chinese company has spent more than \$1 billion buying mines and port facilities across three Papua New Guinea islands, extending Beijing's commercial footprint in a resource sector Canberra and Washington are also courting.
- 2 New Zealand's Treasury has disclosed that Christopher Luxon and Winston Peters committed the country to hosting the 2027 Pacific Islands Forum without Cabinet approval, and told ministers the bid's value for money is not clear.
- 3 Papua New Guinea's Supreme Court has ordered the state to hand over documents on the Solwara deep sea mining project, setting a disclosure precedent seven years after customary landowners went to court.

• TOP STORIES

CHINA-PACIFIC

Chinese company buys Papua New Guinea mines and port facilities for more than \$1 billion

A Chinese company has spent *more than \$1 billion* on mines and port facilities across three islands in Papua New Guinea, Islands Business reported, in a transaction tagged to the Simberi operation. The purchase bundles extraction assets and logistics infrastructure in a single deal. The China in the Pacific ledger last recorded a PRC-related PNG development on September 5, when five leaders were absent from the Palau summit as Australia's treaty run reached Fiji.

per Islands Business: "Chinese firm buys PNG gold mine"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Former ambassador says Beijing growing 'smug', faults Coalition's response to coercion

Graham Fletcher, Australia's ambassador in Beijing from 2019 to 2023, said some Coalition MPs seemed "almost delighted" at being targeted by China and "paraded" the list of 14 grievances handed over by Chinese diplomats. His posting spanned the collapse of bilateral ties in 2020-21 and the relationship's stabilisation after Labor's 2022 election win. Fletcher also said China under **Xi Jinping** is increasingly "smug" and closed off to new ideas, warning that ideological fixations risk sapping the country's entrepreneurial drive.

per ABC News: "Former China ambassador warns Beijing is becoming 'smug' and closed"

AU-POLITICS

Rinehart backs Hanson's campaign against Hastie

Gina Rinehart once supported the Liberal MP **Andrew Hastie** and has now thrown her support behind **Pauline Hanson** and One Nation's plan to bring him down, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. The feud escalated this week over a One Nation animated cartoon labelling the former SAS officer a "traitor", which Hanson has refused to withdraw. The RSL has made a rare political intervention in Hastie's defence.

per Sydney Morning Herald: "Why Rinehart is pushing to make Hastie an outcast, and backing Hanson to bring him down"

• OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Rudd warns Australia risks becoming a 'second-rate country' — **Kevin Rudd** told the National Press Club that Australia risks becoming a "second-rate country" without a "radical change in our national psychology". The address, replayed on ABC Radio National Breakfast, framed complacency as a strategic problem rather than a domestic one. Rudd separately recounted how a network of senior businessmen arranged his introduction to the Pfizer chief Albert Bourla. · ABC Politics

AU-DEFENSE

Universities rebel against national security rules for research — Australian universities are clashing with the federal government over new national security rules governing research, The Australian reported. The rules cover the same technology-protection and foreign-collaboration terrain that underpins Australia's science cooperation with the United States and United Kingdom. No resolution timetable was reported. · The Australian

AU-POLITICS

Albanese moves on migration after Burke speech cancelled — **Anthony Albanese** is scrambling to take the heat out of the migration debate after a speech by Home Affairs Minister **Tony Burke** was cancelled, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. The paper frames the plan as an attempt to draw in Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** while squeezing One Nation. Migration policy has dominated the past week of federal argument alongside the Hastie dispute. · Sydney Morning Herald

[Australia marks 25 years since the September 11 attacks](#) — Australia, the United States, and the rest of the world marked the 25th anniversary of the September 11 terrorist attacks. ABC Radio National carried an interview with former prime minister **John Howard**, who was in Washington on the day, as part of its anniversary coverage. · Sydney Morning Herald

• STAT OF THE DAY

\$1 billion

Chinese purchase of PNG mines and port facilities

A single Chinese transaction covering assets across three Papua New Guinea islands exceeds a billion Australian dollars, in a sector Canberra and Washington are also courting.

Islands Business

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · ABC POLITICS

[British envoy fields questions on UK yard capacity for SSN-AUKUS timetable](#)

Acting British High Commissioner to Australia **Dr Brian Jones** discussed defence budgets, shipyard capacity, and the timetable for Australia's submarine acquisition on ABC's Global Roaming, five years after AUKUS was announced. The programme noted that while most debate centres on the United States and the promised Virginia-class boats, the ultimate goal is the British-designed vessels. Jones was also asked how the United Kingdom views China's increasing forays into the Pacific.

• PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

[PNG Supreme Court orders release of Solwara deep sea mining documents](#)

Opponents of the Solwara deep sea mining project won a further ruling requiring Papua New Guinea's government to release project documents. The Centre for Environmental Law and Community Rights sued the Mineral Resources Authority and the Conservation and Environment Protection Authority in 2019; a 2024 Supreme Court order to hand over the mining licence and environmental permit has still not been met by the Mineral Resources Authority. CELCOR executive director **Peter Bosip** called the delays "a delayed tactic by the MRA and SEPA to suppress the customary landowners".

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

[Pilot track opens on 1,300km road linking Port Moresby and Lae](#)

Papua New Guinea's government has opened a pilot track on a new road connecting Port Moresby to Lae, spanning *1,300 kilometres*. Prime Minister **James Marape** made the drive of more than 18 hours across the mainland in a ministerial convoy. The route is intended to carry essential supplies between the country's two largest cities.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

[PNG launches HPV vaccination targeting 60,000 girls in first phase](#)

Papua New Guinea has begun an anti-cervical cancer vaccination programme whose first phase is expected to reach about *60,000 eligible girls*. Alongside school-based delivery, the government will run the programme through health facilities and community outreach so that girls who are out of school or far from services are not left behind.

SAMOA · ABC PACIFIC

Samoa approves pilot on online voting for citizens overseas

Samoa's government has approved a pilot project to investigate how Samoans living abroad could cast votes online, reviving a contested debate over diaspora suffrage. **Teleiai Edwin Puni**, a chief based in New Zealand, said diaspora votes would add value to Samoa's development, noting that many who left to find opportunities were "always contributing back to Samoa". Opinion is mixed both among residents and the diaspora.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji's prime minister denies lobbying chiefs to delay the general election

Fiji's prime minister denied lobbying the Great Council of Chiefs to delay the general election, PACNEWS reported. A separate item in the same bulletin said the Constitutional Review Commission's report is unlikely to affect the election timetable. Transparency Solomon Islands used the bulletin to argue that democracy "does not end at the ballot box".

TONGA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tonga's deputy PM says no community is too remote for an effective warning

Tonga's deputy prime minister told a regional gathering that no community is too remote to receive an effective early warning, as PACNEWS reported calls for stronger Pacific warning systems in the face of growing climate risk. Another item in the bulletin reported that Pacific climate plans may rest on the wrong picture of rising sea levels, and that justice leaders have been urged to unite against organised crime.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Forum urged to widen the Regional Action Plan on Peace and Security

An Islands Business commentary argues the Pacific Islands Forum has "an important opportunity to ensure that the Regional Action Plan on Peace and Security does more", tying peace to climate, justice, and inclusion rather than a narrow security frame. The piece follows the Koror leaders meeting.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · RNZ PACIFIC

Treasury says Luxon and Peters committed New Zealand to hosting the 2027 Forum without Cabinet approval

Christopher Luxon and **Winston Peters** did not consult Cabinet before committing New Zealand to host the Pacific Islands Forum in 2027, the Treasury said. Budget 2026 committed \$20 million across this year and next for the summit, with Peters making the offer at a Forum Foreign Ministers meeting in August of last year and the official announcement following in September. March advice to Finance Minister **Nicola Willis** recommended excluding a NZ\$30m funding proposal, said "Cabinet approval was not sought before announcement of the hosting arrangement", and that "the value for money of the bid is not clear"; Willis was separately advised to cut the package to \$10m, closer to the cost of hosting in 2011, since "\$6.4m for policy work" was discretionary or scalable.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

The Australian reports Labor premiers in open revolt against Albanese

The Australian's Inquirer section reports Labor premiers in open revolt and argues **Anthony Albanese**, after an easy run, is now rattled. The piece lands in a week dominated by federal grant controversies, migration argument, and a Queensland credit downgrade.

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Reshuffle chatter builds in Labor ranks despite settled ministry

Albanese has not turned his mind to his next ministry, which is unlikely before 2027, but Labor MPs are already canvassing a reshuffle, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. Any rearrangement would eventually reach the defence, foreign affairs, and Pacific island affairs portfolios.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Labor's \$75m anti-extremism programme failing most participants, paper reports

The government's flagship *\$75 million* anti-extremism programme is failing to reform the vast majority of its participants, The Australian reported. The finding lands as police investigate a man filmed throwing pork products at a mosque in Warragul, Victoria.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Queensland credit rating downgraded for the first time in 17 years

Queensland's credit rating has been cut for the first time in 17 years, The Australian reported, with the paper saying Premier **David Crisafulli** is turning a blind eye to debt. The downgrade was described as imminent in yesterday's reporting and is now confirmed.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Houthis take Mocha and press towards Bab el-Mandeb as Brent holds above \$100

Iran-aligned Houthis seized the Yemeni port city of Mocha and reached the Hanish Islands overlooking the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, while Iranian strikes damaged United States fighter aircraft at a base in Jordan. Control of the strait would give Iran leverage over a second major energy transit corridor. Brent stood at *104.08*, up 6.29 percent.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Greens and Coalition unite to block passenger tax rise

The Greens and the Coalition will combine to block the federal government's increase to the passenger movement charge, The Australian reported, leaving the measure dead on arrival in the Senate. The revenue was booked in the government's forward estimates.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Energy ministers agree to explore lifting Australia's plug-in solar ban

Australia's energy ministers agreed to explore pathways for the "safe deployment" of plug-in solar and batteries, a step towards lifting a ban that keeps the technology from apartment dwellers and renters. The United Kingdom legalised balcony solar last month and New Zealand has flagged plans to do the same within 12 months. Campaigners want a timeline by December.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Modelling warns budget changes will wipe \$1bn from GDP and lift rents

Modelling reported by The Australian warns federal budget changes will wipe *\$1 billion* from GDP and push rents up by five times the increase claimed by Treasurer **Jim Chalmers**. The Treasurer's own figures on the measure have not been revised.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS OF THAILAND

Thailand confirms envoy attended the 55th Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting in Palau

Thailand's foreign ministry published a readout confirming that the Chairman of the Advisory Board to the Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs attended the 55th Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting in the Republic of Palau. The Koror meeting ran from August 30 to September 4, 2026, and passed the Forum chair to Palau.

• UPCOMING

Oct
26

Advance voting opens for New Zealand's general election

Three weeks of early voting begin with foreign and Pacific policy questions, including the Forum hosting commitment, already in dispute.

Nov
7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National, ACT, and NZ First coalition, and Winston Peters' foreign policy, continue.

September 2027

New Zealand hosts the Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting

Treasury has told ministers the hosting costs are unavoidable but that there is significant scope to manage them down.

November 2026

United States midterm elections

President Donald Trump said he expects the Iran war to end after the midterms, a timeline with direct consequences for oil and shipping.

annual, venue
alternates 2026

AUSMIN, the Australia-US Ministerial Consultations

The next round will test United States pressure for higher Australian defence spending and the shape of force posture cooperation.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Mobility provisions in recent Australia-Pacific bilateral agreements

Jane McAdam writes that beyond Tuvalu's climate visa, six Australia-Pacific agreements now recognise mobility as a tool for adaptation, security, and dignity. The piece reads the agreements against Pacific leaders' 2023 endorsement of the

Pacific Regional framework on mobility.

ABC PACIFIC

Tonga preparedness push leans on traditional knowledge and language

Disaster managers in Tonga say constant reminders are needed even where disasters are frequent, and that the language used in warnings adds vital context. The programme is produced by ABC International Development with funding from the Australian Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade.

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

China is poised to lead in research on quantum technologies. Democracies must act

ASPI research finds China is either already ahead or poised to take the lead in quantum technologies, and argues Australia and its democratic partners must act promptly to avoid conceding that lead. Quantum sits inside AUKUS Pillar 2.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

ABC PACIFIC

Scientists put Lae fault line closer to the city centre than thought

Scientists in Papua New Guinea say there is a one-in-four chance a fault line at Lae produces a quake of magnitude 8.5 within the next 50 years, and that the fault runs closer to the central business district than previously understood.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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generated 6:27 AM ET

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